SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #13 · DEBT AND SHAME

"I can never get out of this."

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Where it often comes from

When bills pile up, interest grows, or one setback follows another, the situation can feel like quicksand. Long stress narrows thinking, and past efforts that failed may make a new plan seem pointless. Some people also grew up around families who always owed, which can make debt seem like a permanent condition.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture does not hide how heavy troubles can be. David says he waited patiently for the Lord, who lifted him up from the pit of despair and set his feet upon a rock. Lamentations says the Lord's mercies are new every morning. Paul says we are hard pressed but not crushed, perplexed but not in despair. Proverbs says the plans of the diligent lead to profit. These verses do not promise a quick fix. They say that God lifts, that mornings come, and that steady steps matter.

> *"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope"* (Jeremiah 29:11).

Also see

> "I waited patiently for the LORD; He inclined to me and heard my cry. He lifted me up from the pit of despair, out of the miry clay; He set my feet upon a rock, and made my footsteps firm" (Psalm 40:1–2).

> "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!" (Lamentations 3:22–23).

> "Now may the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace as you believe in Him, so that you may overflow with hope by the power of the Holy Spirit" (Romans 15:13).

> "The plans of the diligent bring plenty, as surely as haste leads to poverty" (Proverbs 21:5).

Common self-statements

- Nothing I do will ever make a difference.
- I will be paying this off forever.
- There is no way out.
- I have tried everything.
- This is just my life now.
- It is too late to fix it.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that nothing will ever change.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that if I cannot pay it all off, there is no point.
- Catastrophizing: Seeing the whole mountain instead of the next step.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling stuck and concluding that I am stuck for good.

Challenging questions

- What exactly do I owe, and have I written the numbers down?
- What progress have I made, even if small?

- What is one thing that has improved in the past year?
- Who has gotten out of a hard situation, and how?
- What options have I not yet explored, such as counseling, restructuring, or support?
- What is the next smallest step?

Truth summary

> This season is heavy, but "never" is a prediction, not a fact. God lifts people out of pits, and His mercies are new every morning. I can take one clear step at a time and ask for help along the way.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Hopeless
- Hardship
- Trust
- Plans
- God, All Powerful

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Money/Riches

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Chain Breaker — Zach Williams
Christ offers rescue and freedom to people who feel trapped by their past.

Greater — MercyMe
God's presence and grace challenge shame and the need to win everyone's approval.

Victory in Jesus — Joy Gardner, Cynthia Clawson, Mike Allen and Reggie Smith
This classic gospel hymn celebrates Christ's rescue and the hope of life with Him.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can never get out of this"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can never get out of this." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly do I owe?
- ☐ What progress have I made?
- ☐ What one step can I take this week?
- ☐ Who can help me look at options?
- ☐ What has God done for me in hard times before?
- ☐ Where am I predicting "never"?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ "Never" is a feeling, not a fact.
- ☐ God's mercies are new every morning.
- ☐ Small steps add up.
- ☐ I can ask for help to find options.
- ☐ I have survived hard seasons before.
- ☐ God has plans for my good and my hope.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Jeremiah 29:11**
  "For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans to prosper you and not to harm you, to give you a future and a hope."
- ☐ **Psalm 40:1–2**
  "I waited patiently for the LORD; He inclined to me and heard my cry. He lifted me up from the pit of despair, out of the miry clay; He set my feet upon a rock, and made my footsteps firm."
- ☐ **Lamentations 3:22–23**
  "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] One step, one number: Each week, write the amount you owe and one step you took, however small. Watch the page fill up.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Lamentations 3:22–23 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God's mercies are new every morning, so I can take one step today.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Hopeless" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Write down the whole picture. List every debt, balance, and minimum payment. Facing the numbers lowers the fear.
- [ ] Choose the next step. Pick one thing, such as a call, a budget, or a conversation, and do it this week.
- [ ] Seek qualified help. Contact a nonprofit credit counseling agency or a trusted advisor about options.
- [ ] Mark small wins. Put a visible check on the calendar for every step taken.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can never get out of this": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step forward
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can never get out of this.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You lift people out of pits. When I feel stuck, remind me that Your mercies are new each morning. Show me the next step and give me hope that this will not last forever. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.